

two, it's a way to bring a powerful and complete desktop computing environment to an enormous number of people who get a phone before they get a desktop. It will be a bridge into their computing life.

I think Ubuntu for Android is a particularly interesting offering not just for enterprises but also for the high growth markets like India. We will come to market in India in conjunction with our partners. So Canonical is not going to start making phones. We will follow the same process that we do on PCs, where we come with a partner like Dell. In the case of Ubuntu for Android, we will come in with a phone partner or maybe a telco. It will take a little bit of time to put these relationships in place but it is a very key part of the proposition. So, hopefully, the next time we talk, it will not be about deploying thousands of Ubuntu desktops somewhere but about the millions of phones that run Ubuntu for Android on them.

Upcoming projects of Canonical...

Q You said Ubuntu for Android will be big for India. We do accept that, but Android already is huge for India. One doesn't know when Google will come up with a similar concept. Who do you see as your competition and will Ubuntu for Android be available on cost-friendly devices as Android is?

We already see people stretching Android into larger form factors. It first stretched into tablets, though the first version of Android for tablets was not so strong. The newer Android tablet versions are getting better. We are already seeing people trying to stretch that to a desktop and it doesn't work very well. There is a lot of Android being used to design pointing interactions and touch interactions as opposed to a mouse or a keyboard. But there have been some awkward experiences that people have had. From the perspective of the user experience, we are very comfortable that we have a much better desktop offering. That's our bread and butter and core strength. Having said that though, Android is competition. People will try to pull and stretch Android in different ways. Even with Windows 8 and its emerging natural interface, you can already see that they are trying to put the same interface on different form factors. It's similar on phones, tablets and on the early desktop previews that are out. But some things work well and some things don't stretch so well. I think there will be competition in this 'converged device' space. We think we will have a very credible and strong offering, but others will try as well.

Q When do we see Ubuntu for Android coming in, finally?

I do not have a date for you and the schedule for that depends more on our partners than us, because it's not our products or devices that will be getting launched.

Q What about Canonical's tablet?

We have said that we will be working on a tablet. A part of the inspiration behind redesigning the desktop interface into Unity was to understand how to work across this range. This trend towards the convergence of devices and a continual but not identical computing experience was our clear intent, a couple of years ago. We knew that the previous desktop paradigm didn't stretch, and learning and designing something that would expand on a spectrum of devices was part of the motivation for Unity several years ago. You have seen that result in Ubuntu TV, which again is a similar but not identical experience. Ubuntu for Android is a bit of a different experience. While it brings the desktop experience to the phone, we are also exploring tablets but do not have a product announcement on that yet.

Q You recently launched a laptop for developers along with Dell...

'Launched' is too strong a word. It was Dell's project called Sputnik, which is an effort on their part to be responsive to what people want from their products. They are trying to listen to their customers. One of their target markets is developers and, hence, a developer laptop. So we did some work together and looked at what developers really want on their laptops and one of their top choices is Ubuntu. Dell did a marketing test to see whether there would be a market for this laptop. The model is XPS 13 with Ubuntu pre-installed and configured in a developer environment. They got a very positive response during test marketing but they are still to decide whether to actually launch the product or not. So what you saw was just the floating of an idea to check out if developers would buy something like this. It was testing the tides rather than actually launching it.

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Q What is your conclusion on Dell's XPS 13?

I think it's a great idea. Ubuntu is a natural fit for developers. There was a survey done recently by the Eclipse Foundation about which operating system developers would want to use. Windows was first, but Ubuntu was a very strong second. We know that Ubuntu appeals to developers. Much of our enterprise usage is on developer workstations and much of our server use comes from the fact that developers are actually using it. Dell still needs to look at whether developers will specifically buy such a machine. For us, the answer to whether developers and Ubuntu go together, is a definitive 'yes'. 